

SANTA MONICA COLLEGE · QFE CLUB PRESENTS

QUANT RUSH

Strike signal in the noise.

KICKOFF · TUE OCT 13

OCT 13 → NOV 22 · 100% ONLINE

Engraving: H. Sandham, “The Sluice,” The Century, 1883 · Public domain

WHAT IT IS

A six-week online quant competition

Build models on a financial dataset. Every submission updates a public leaderboard; a private one, revealed at the end, decides the winners.

Free

Registration and Kaggle both cost nothing.

Online

Compete from anywhere, on any laptop with a browser.

Open

California community college students, 18 and over. No experience needed.

THE TASK

Rank the assets before they move

12

hours of history for each asset

~200

assets in each market snapshot

4

hours ahead to rank them over

Most of what moves is noise. The challenge is to find the signal in it.

HOW YOU ARE SCORED

Get the order right, era by era

1. An era is one moment in time, with about 200 assets in it.
2. Within each era we compare your ranking with the true ranking (Spearman correlation).
3. Your score is the average over all eras. Only the order matters, not the size of your numbers.

1

A perfect ordering

≈ 0

A random guess

PUBLIC VS PRIVATE

The public leaderboard lies.

It shows about 30% of the test data and updates after every submission. The other 70%, the private leaderboard, decides the final ranking and stays hidden until the deadline.

Chase the public score and you can fall on the private one. That is what Fool's Gold is for.

HOW TO JOIN · LIVE

Four steps to the leaderboard

1 REGISTER

Fill in the form at smcqfec.com with your college email.

2 KAGGLE ACCOUNT

Make a free one. It takes two minutes.

3 JOIN

Use the Kaggle link on smcqfec.com and click Join.

4 SUBMIT

Five submissions a day per team, starting today.

SCAN TO REGISTER

smcqfec.com

Do steps 1 to 3 now, while we are in the room.

TEAMS

Solo, or up to four

4	Nov 15	1
people in a team, at most	last day to merge teams	Kaggle account per person

Need teammates? Say so on the registration form or ask on Discord. Teams that merge after Nov 15 are not eligible for awards.

THE MINER'S CODE

The rules at a glance

SUBMISSIONS

5 a day per team. Pick 2 final ones before the deadline.

DATA

Competition files only. Libraries like pandas and LightGBM are fine.

AI TOOLS

Allowed for learning and for writing code.

DON'T SALT THE MINE

No tracing the data to its source, no using the test set's structure.

SHARING

Share publicly on Kaggle. Not privately between teams.

PRIZES

Registered California community college students, 18 and over.

AWARDS

One leaderboard, four ways to win

MOTHER LODE

1st, 2nd and 3rd place on the private leaderboard.

GREENHORN'S LUCK

The best team whose members are all first-timers.

THE PROSPECTOR'S REPORT

The best memo, judged by the board. Rank does not count.

FOOL'S GOLD

The biggest fall from the public top 10 to the private board. A joke, with a real prize.

Prizes are in kind, never cash. We announce them on smcqfec.com and on Discord.

THE CLAIM TRAIL

Six weeks, ten dates

Tue Oct 13
KICKOFF
The competition opens.

Tue Oct 20
WORKSHOP 1
Python, pandas, a first submission.

Tue Oct 27
WORKSHOP 2
The data and the metric.

Tue Nov 3
WORKSHOP 3
Features and baselines.

Tue Nov 10
WORKSHOP 4
Validation and overfitting.

Sun Nov 15
MERGE DEADLINE
Registration closes. Last day to merge teams.

Tue Nov 17
FINAL SPRINT
Ensembling and Q&A.

Sun Nov 22
THE ASSAY
Submissions close, 11:59 p.m. PT.

Wed Nov 25
MEMOS DUE
The Prospector's Report.

Tue Dec 1
PAYDIRT
Winners announced.

PICKS & SHOVELS

Tuesday workshops

Date	Session	What we cover
Tue Oct 20	Picks & Shovels I	Python, pandas, a first Kaggle notebook
Tue Oct 27	Reading the Vein	Exploring the data, understanding the metric
Tue Nov 3	Refining the Ore	Feature engineering and baseline models
Tue Nov 10	What Glitters	Validation, and why the public board lies
Tue Nov 17	The Last Dig	Ensembling, Q&A, final submissions

In person at SMC, 11:15 a.m. to 12:15 p.m. in MSB 207. Optional, and for SMC students.

WHERE TO START

Open the Getting Started notebook

It is in the Code tab of the competition on Kaggle. In about a minute it takes you from zero to a submission:

- Load the data
- Take a first look at eras and columns
- Make a one-line prediction
- Score it locally
- Write submission.csv

```
prediction = -ret_00
```

A one-line rule from the notebook. No machine learning yet: that part is up to you.

THE PROSPECTOR'S REPORT

Thinking counts, not only code

Write one to two pages on how you would attack the problem and why. The board picks the most insightful memo. Your leaderboard rank does not count.

Wed Nov 25

11:59 p.m. Pacific

Email

qfec.smc@gmail.com, with your name or team in the subject

Open

to every registered participant, with or without a submission

QUESTIONS · SCAN TO JOIN

Dig in.

Register, make your Kaggle account, and get a first baseline submitted by next Tuesday.

WEBSITE

smcqfec.com

DISCORD

discord.gg/MUPdvSAV4M

INSTAGRAM

@qfecsmc